of poverty itself had been invisibilized in the public discourse—it is no longer fashionable within the academia, we do not address it through our media, and our everyday interactions also seem oblivious to the glaring poverty and powerlessness of our fellow Indians. We are more fixated on achieving the ‘superpower’ status or the imagined glory of being a ‘Vishwaguru’.

It is a sign of our times that now the term ‘gareebi (poverty)’ has lost political currency. It has been replaced by new categories such as ‘aam aadmi’. This, despite the fact that a huge section of our people are impoverished. This episode revealed the enduring truth and relevance of Gandhi ji’s famous talisman. When I think of the common man now, I try and picture that man and many more like him. The Yatra thus re-sensitized me to the pressing question of poverty in our nation.

The second lesson was on the role of religion in society and politics. Given the hatred and violence that had been perpetrated in the name of religion in the past ten years, I had started to develop an aversion to religion. However, I experienced religion differently on the Yatra, which made me believe that religiosity is not undesirable as long as it is rooted in empathy, compassion and love. What we were witnessing was the cynical use of religion to divide and rule. However, it could also be used to unite and serve. That was also Gandhi ji’s idea.

Throughout the Yatra, we were welcomed into the premises of religious places—whether they were temples, mosques, churches or gurudwaras. Moreover, there were many religious people and even priests of different religions who participated in the Yatra. However, their participation only enriched our campaign. It did not lead to any hatred, which has unfortunately become commonplace within our sociopolitical culture these days. One experience in particular forced me to re-evaluate my stance on this issue.

Every day we used to get up at the crack of dawn and start off at six in the morning, come sun, rain or snow. This disturbed the morning routine of most people. One of them was Digvijaya Singh, who was in charge of organizing the entire Yatra. He has a public image of a staunch secularist.